

Interview Thesis Brief

DIRECTOR OF APPLIED AI - RUSSELL DUDEK

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Build the common law of AI-enabled work.

Turn practice-specific experiments into trusted workflow precedent without erasing legal judgment, privilege, context, or accountability.

THE REAL MANDATE

Lead the operating layer that converts partner and practice demand into a concentrated portfolio of governed, adopted, measurable AI-enabled workflows - while developing practice-aligned managers and making reusable delivery standards improve with every matter.

WHY NOW

Function formation
Parallel public hiring for practice-aligned AI managers and a KM / Practice Technology director signals an integrated operating model.

Cross-practice complexity
Corporate, Litigation, Regulatory, and White Collar share technical components but retain different evidence, privilege, and authority conditions.

Client-service pressure
The function must prove better matter execution, attorney leverage, quality, and responsiveness - not merely tool activity.

FIVE LEADERSHIP OUTCOMES

OUTCOME	WHAT CHANGES	EVIDENCE
Portfolio focus	Demand is sequenced by client outcome, readiness, risk, adoption owner, and reuse potential.	Decision latency; stopped work; pilot-to-production path
Delivery standards	Prompt, retrieval, agent, evaluation, quality, and release conventions become inspectable and reusable.	Evaluation coverage; defects; rework; exceptions
Knowledge alignment	Workflows and their sources, taxonomies, ownership, and freshness evolve together.	Coverage; freshness; source corrections; ownership
Adoption	Training, demos, office hours, feedback, and practice leadership reinforce real workflow use.	Repeat use; task completion; support demand; abandonment
Value	Leadership sees operating and client-service evidence, not vanity usage counts.	Cycle time; quality; leverage; responsiveness; matter economics

OPERATING MODEL

The Applied AI Reporter is an operating metaphor, not legal authority. It gives practice leaders, AI managers, KM, Technology, Risk, and leadership one record for deciding what a workflow is allowed to do, what evidence supports it, and how far it should scale.

THE RECORD

1. Fact pattern Attorney task, client objective, users, matter conditions, and consequence.
2. Knowledge record Approved sources, provenance, taxonomy, access, freshness, and content owner.
3. Human authority What AI may assist, what a lawyer must decide, escalation, and override.

THE TREATMENT

4. Evaluation Task-specific quality, citations, omissions, agreement, red-team, and release evidence.
5. Adoption and ownership Training, support, workflow fit, feedback, maintenance, and retirement owner.
6. Value evidence Measured effect on matter execution, attorney leverage, quality, and client service.

FOUR EXPLICIT DISPOSITIONS

DISPOSITION	DECISION	REQUIRED DISCIPLINE
Matter prototype	Bounded learning; not yet a reusable pattern.	Narrow access, named reviewer, clear stop condition.
Practice pattern	Repeatable inside one practice with documented exceptions.	Representative evaluation, KM owner, adoption support.
Cross-practice candidate	Components may transfer; assumptions must be retested.	Compare fact patterns, authority, knowledge, and adaptation burden.
Firm standard	Maintained capability with explicit scope and exception handling.	Lifecycle ownership, monitoring, revalidation, retirement criteria.

DIRECTOR'S ROLE

Make the treatment decision visible. Ensure the team is not rewarded for pilot volume, nor blocked by ceremony. Concentrate effort where a useful workflow can become a trusted pattern and where the learning justifies broader investment.

DECISION RIGHTS

ACTOR	OWNS	MUST NOT BE BLURRED
Practice leadership / matter owners	Client objective, legal judgment, release, material exceptions, adoption sponsorship.	AI does not acquire legal authority through technical capability.
Director of Applied AI	Portfolio, team expectations, delivery standards, evaluation discipline, scaling decisions, leadership reporting.	Central standards do not erase legitimate practice variation.
Applied AI Managers	Practice discovery, workflow delivery, enablement, feedback, performance evidence.	Local speed does not bypass common quality and governance.
KM / Practice Technology	Knowledge content, taxonomy, precedent resources, workflow integration, maintenance.	A model cannot compensate for unowned or stale knowledge.
Security, Risk, OGC	Data handling, privilege, vendor diligence, policy, consequential boundaries.	Controls must enter design before release, not after adoption.
IT / vendors	Platforms, integration, supportability, observability, resilience, commercial terms.	Build-vs-buy is an operating decision, not a feature comparison.

PORTFOLIO SCORECARD - CATEGORIES, NOT INVENTED TARGETS

- **Flow:** intake-to-decision, build cycle, pilot-to-production, time blocked by dependency.
 - **Quality:** task success, citation validity, omission, reviewer correction, defect and incident patterns.
 - **Knowledge:** source coverage, freshness, ownership, taxonomy fit, retrieval failures.
 - **Authority and risk:** review agreement, escalation, overrides, access and privilege exceptions.
- **Adoption:** eligible users, repeat use, workflow completion, abandonment, support and training signals.
 - **Value:** measured cycle time, rework, attorney leverage, client responsiveness, matter economics.
 - **Reuse:** adaptation effort, component reuse, practice exceptions, maintenance load.
 - **Lifecycle:** owner health, monitoring, model or knowledge change, revalidation, retirement.

OPERATING CADENCE

Weekly	Practice-manager delivery review: decisions, blockers, quality evidence, adoption, next release.
Monthly	Cross-practice precedent review: promote, limit, repair, reuse, retire.
Quarterly	Leadership portfolio review: value evidence, risk, capacity, vendor posture, investment and stop decisions.

VERIFIED EVIDENCE MAP

ROLE NEED	TRANSFERABLE EVIDENCE
Lead distributed applied AI delivery	Current director-level transformation across robotics, operations, quality, enterprise systems, customer workflows, telemetry, and AI-assisted work.
Standards, evaluation, and quality	High-reliability engineering and quality systems at Compunetics; readiness, human-judgment, evaluation, governance, and agentic workflow patterns through DudeWorth.
Adoption and change	Standard work, training, visual management, operating cadence, cross-functional launches, and frontline enablement across Amazon, Vape-Jet, Cardinal, and advisory work.
Executive and technical translation	Career-long bridge among leadership, engineers, operations, customers, regulators, vendors, and technical specialists.
Measurable operating value	Customer-backward delivery, throughput and quality visibility, feedback loops, issue flow, and evidence-based prioritization at scale.

STRONGEST PLAUSIBLE OBJECTION - HANDLED AFFIRMATIVELY

Calibration: Russell does not claim direct law-firm or legal-technology tenure. The day-one requirement is disciplined practice immersion: matter shadowing, legal-workflow deconstruction, privilege and professional-responsibility controls, partnership decision dynamics, and matter-economics fluency.

Why the case remains strong: the role also requires a leader who can make emerging technology operational, develop managers, build reusable delivery mechanisms, align knowledge with workflow, establish quality controls, drive adoption, measure value, manage vendors, and communicate credibly across executives and specialists. That integrated operating record is verified.

EXECUTIVE INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

1. When this role is successful twelve months from now, what will partners say has become materially easier or more reliable in matter execution?
2. Where does demand currently break down: identifying use cases, access to knowledge, technical capacity, evaluation, governance, practice sponsorship, or sustained adoption?
3. What decision should be firm-wide, and what authority do practice leaders expect to retain?
4. How will the Senior Director of AI, this role, the Director of KM and Practice Technology, the CIO, and practice leadership divide portfolio and release decisions?
5. Which current workflow has the strongest evidence of attorney pull, and which has generated activity without durable use?
6. How does Covington want to define value where direct time savings may affect leverage, pricing, realization, client expectations, or matter strategy?
7. What is the strongest concern partners have about scaling AI-enabled work, and what evidence would change that concern?